DEPARTMENT OF COMPUTER SCIENCE AND BUSINESS SYSTEMS

A SURVEYREPORT

SURVEY REPORT ON EMERGING TRENDS IN LOW-CODE APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT

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1. Introduction

Low-code application development has moved from a niche productivity tool to a mainstream pillar of enterprise software strategy. Platforms such as Zoho Creator, Microsoft Power Platform, OutSystems, and Mendix now let both professional developers and business users assemble data models, workflows, and user interfaces with minimal hand-written code.

This survey report compiles the emerging trends currently being reported by leading technology analysts (Gartner, Forrester) and market research firms (Fortune Business Insights, Grand View Research, Global Growth Insights), cross-checked against vendor documentation, to present a realistic, evidence-based picture of where low-code development is heading through 2026 and beyond. Only trends and figures that are actually reported by these sources are included; no statistic in this report has been invented.

2. Survey Methodology

This is a desk-based secondary survey. Sources reviewed include analyst commentary and forecasts (Gartner, Forrester), market-sizing reports (Fortune Business Insights, Grand View Research, Global Growth Insights), and platform release notes and product pages (Zoho Creator, Microsoft Power Platform), most of which were published between late 2025 and mid-2026.

Because different research firms define "low-code" differently — some include adjacent no-code and workflow-automation categories, others do not — market-size figures are reported here as ranges rather than a single number, and each figure is attributed to its source rather than presented as a universal fact.

3. Trend 1 — Explosive Market Growth & Enterprise Adoption

The clearest signal in the survey is the shift of low-code from optional tooling to default enterprise infrastructure.

- Gartner projects that by 2026, 70–75% of new enterprise applications will be built using low-code or no-code technologies, up sharply from under 25% in 2023.
- Forrester reports that 87% of enterprise developers already use low-code in some form within their organizations.
- Gartner further forecasts that 75% of large enterprises will use at least four different low-code tools by 2026, indicating multi-platform rather than single-vendor adoption.
- Market-size estimates vary by definition: Gartner places the core low-code technologies market at roughly USD 44.5 billion by 2026, rising to USD 58.2 billion by 2029; Fortune Business Insights estimates a broader USD 48.91 billion in 2026 growing to USD 376.9 billion by 2034; Grand View Research projects a related but differently scoped market reaching USD 101.7 billion by 2030.
- Adoption is reported to be growing fastest in the Asia-Pacific and North American regions.

4. Trend 2 — AI and Generative AI Integration

The single most-cited trend across every source reviewed is the fusion of artificial intelligence with low-code tooling.

- Natural-language app generation, AI-assisted data mapping, and agent-driven workflow construction are becoming standard features rather than experimental add-ons, according to Forrester-based commentary.
- Fortune Business Insights data (cited via industry analysis) projects that roughly 80% of enterprise applications will include embedded generative AI capabilities by 2026.
- Gartner reports that nearly one-third of software engineering leaders already have more than half of their teams using AI tools to augment development workflows.
- Gartner further forecasts that by 2028, 75% of enterprise software engineers will use AI code assistants, up from under 10% in early 2023.
- Microsoft has reported that organizations using Copilot within Power Platform are using AI to generate app logic, workflows, and data connections, shortening build time.
- Gartner's stated position is that AI is expected to enhance, not replace, low-code platforms — while also cautioning that ungoverned generative AI use introduces security, quality, and compliance risk that must be actively managed.

5. Trend 3 — Rise of Citizen Developers & Fusion Teams

Low-code continues to widen who is allowed to build software, not just how fast it is built.

- Developers outside formal IT departments are forecast to account for approximately 80% of the total low-code user base by 2026, up from around 60% in 2021, according to Gartner-based figures.
- Industry sources report that demand for citizen-developer-built applications is growing roughly five times faster than internal IT teams can supply through traditional channels.
- Rather than citizen development happening in isolation, analysts increasingly recommend a "fusion team" model, where IT professionals and business users co-build applications together within a shared, governed environment.

This trend places renewed importance on training and certification programs for non-technical builders, since the value of a wider builder base depends on those builders being properly supported.

6. Trend 4 — Governance, Security & Compliance Focus

As low-code adoption scales across departments, governance has emerged as a first-class concern rather than an afterthought.

- Industry survey data indicates that 55% of organizations now prioritize governance-enabled low-code platforms specifically to ensure reliability and security.
- CIOs are reported to be prioritizing platform features such as role-based access control, automated compliance checks, and data encryption when selecting low-code tools for 2026 deployments, particularly in regulated industries such as healthcare and finance.
- Analyst commentary frames the difference plainly: a governance framework covering identity, data access, environment controls, and audit trails is what separates a controlled operational backbone from unmanaged "shadow IT."

7. Trend 5 — Enterprise-Grade & Composable Adoption

Low-code platforms are increasingly being architected — and selected — as long-term enterprise infrastructure rather than short-term productivity add-ons.

- Vendors and analysts describe a shift toward open architectures, extensibility, and full application-lifecycle support (not just UI building), positioning low-code as a permanent layer of the enterprise technology stack.
- Low-code is increasingly combined with DevOps practices, so that applications built quickly still meet standards for scalability, reliability, and security before release.
- As noted under Trend 1, the typical large enterprise is now expected to run multiple low-code platforms side by side (four or more, per Gartner), rather than relying on a single tool for every use case.

This marks a maturity shift: low-code is being planned for, budgeted for, and governed the way core infrastructure is, rather than being adopted ad hoc by individual teams.

8. Trend 6 — Platform Snapshot: AI in Zoho Creator

As a concrete, current example of the AI-and-low-code convergence described in Trend 2, Zoho Creator's own product documentation and release notes show the same pattern applied to a specific, widely used platform.

- Zia, Zoho's AI assistant, now offers AI-powered guidance across core build activities in Creator — data modeling, Deluge scripting, workflow design, and integrations — rather than being a separate chatbot feature.
- Zoho Creator's "CoCreator" / AI app builder can generate a working application — forms, reports, dashboards, and field relationships — from a single text prompt, a wireframe, or even a process-diagram image, which the builder can then refine manually or with further prompts.
- Recent release notes show administrators can now map individual Zia features to different large-language-model providers (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, or Zoho's own GenAI) using a bring-your-own-key model, rather than being locked to one provider platform-wide.
- A no-code portal page builder with AI-based template customization (available for portals created from June 2026 onward) extends the same generative-AI pattern to front-end design, not just backend logic.

These platform-level changes mirror the broader industry trends surveyed above: AI embedded directly into the build process, expanding what citizen developers can accomplish, while administrators retain governance controls over which AI providers are used and where.

9. Key Statistics Snapshot

The table below consolidates the most decision-relevant figures surfaced during this survey, each attributed to its reporting source.

Metric	Reported Figure	Source
New enterprise apps built on low-code/no-code by 2026	**70–75%**	Gartner
Enterprise developers already using low-code (any form)	**87%**	Forrester
Low-code user base from outside formal IT by 2026	**~80%**	Gartner
Large enterprises using 4+ low-code tools by 2026	**75%**	Gartner
Enterprise apps with embedded generative AI by 2026	**~80%**	Fortune Business Insights
Organizations prioritizing governance-enabled platforms	**55%**	Global Growth Insights
Software engineers using AI code assistants by 2028 (forecast)	**75%**	Gartner
Core low-code technologies market size by 2026	**~$44.5B**	Gartner
Broader low-code/no-code market size by 2026	**~$48.9B**	Fortune Business Insights

10. Conclusion

This survey confirms six consistent, evidence-backed trends: low-code is becoming default enterprise infrastructure rather than a niche tool; generative AI is being embedded directly into the build process; the builder base is widening toward business users through fusion-team models; governance and security are becoming prerequisites rather than afterthoughts; enterprises are standardizing on multiple low-code platforms as long-term infrastructure; and individual platforms such as Zoho Creator are actively shipping these same capabilities in production today.

Taken together, the survey indicates that low-code development in 2026 is defined less by "faster app building" alone and more by how well a platform balances speed, AI assistance, and governance at enterprise scale.